decomposers are limited by their respective resources. Competition occurs between species on each of these three trophic levels. They also found that herbivore populations are seldom limited by the supply of plants, but are limited by predators, so they are unlikely to compete with other herbivores for common resources. The paper highlighted the important role of top-down forces (predation) in ecosystems, and bottom-up forces (food supply).

American ecologist Robert Paine was the first to use the term “trophic cascade” when, in 1980, he described changes in food webs that were brought about by the experimental removal of predatory starfish from the intertidal zone in Washington State. The concept of trophic cascades is now generally accepted, although debate continues as to how widespread they are.